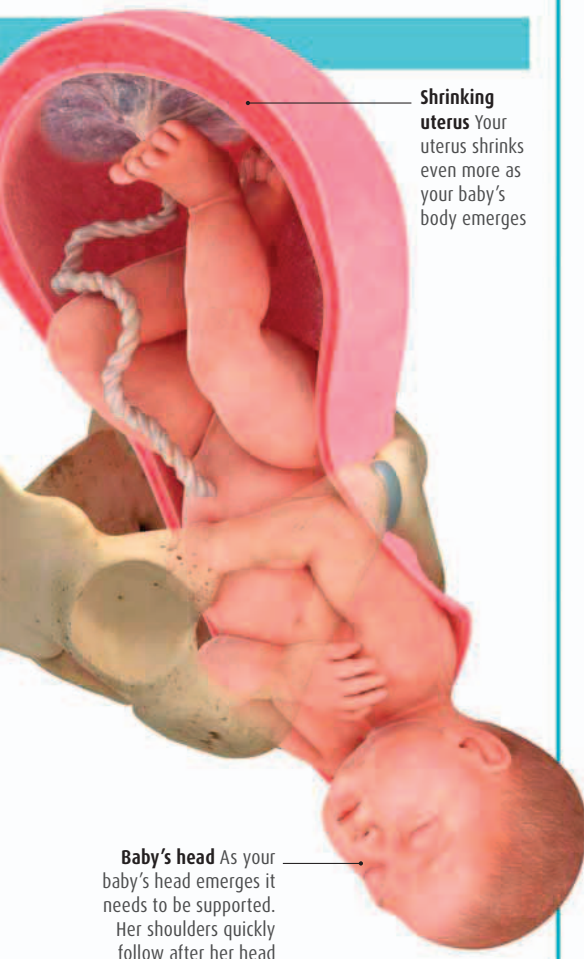


your pelvis provides. You will feel a sense of satisfaction with every push—you are getting closer to meeting your baby.

Crowning and birth

As labor progresses and your baby's head presses against the pelvic floor, she rotates by about 45 degrees so that her face looks toward your spine. This position enables her to fit her head through your "pubic arch"—a pair of pelvic bones that form an arch. When her head makes it through these bones, your baby "crowns"—her head is out. Crowning can prompt a burning feeling, known as the "ring of fire." At this point, she turns another 45 degrees so that she can fit her shoulders through your pelvis; her head will turn too. Once the shoulders have made the turn, they, too, emerge into the world, quickly followed by the rest of your baby's body.



3 The rest of your baby's body comes out soon after the head. Her shoulders will come out one after the other, followed quickly by the rest of her body.

Q Are there positions that make it easier for me to give birth?

Some positions naturally open up your pelvis so are more efficient for delivery. Ultimately, the position you choose should be the one you find most comfortable.

The more upright you are in the second stage of labor, the more you have gravity on your side to help with the descent of your baby. One of the most efficient positions to give birth is in the squatting position. This has all the benefits of standing up (see p.211), but also opens out your pelvic bones, creating space for your baby to pass through more easily. Some researchers believe that a woman who labors standing up and gives birth squatting can reduce her labor by up to an hour. If you want to squat during the final stages of your labor, you will need to have strong thighs! Ask your birthing partner to hold you under your armpits to ease the strain on your muscles. Other positions that have the same beneficial effects are resting on all-fours and the kneeling pose. For kneeling, you will need physical support since it requires good balance. If your baby is being monitored, you might have to be in a bed, but follow the guidance from your nurse.



Supported squat

Your partner can support you from behind, or you can face him, putting your arms around his neck while he holds you firmly under your arms.



Kneeling on all fours You can try doing this on top of a bed or on the floor. In this position, your birth partner can give support and gently massage your back.

Q How long will it take to push my baby out?

This partly depends upon whether or not this is your first baby. First babies may take up to three hours from the start of the second stage of labor to be born, whereas second babies can take up to two hours or less. The position of your baby within your pelvis will also affect how long she takes to be born. Your doctor will stay with you during this stage, so listen to guidance on what's happening and when to push. The doctor will monitor your progress now by looking and feeling, and will also check your baby's heart rate for about one minute every five minutes or so. Some women worry that this frequent checking means something is wrong, but it's quite normal.

Try to remember that the second stage of labor is not measured by the length of time it

takes, but by forward progress—as long as your labor is progressing, even if it seems slow, you and your baby are doing fine.

Q Is there anything I can do to speed up the delivery of my baby?

An upright position can make labor quicker, but bear in mind that speed is not always best.

A controlled, well-managed labor allows your perineum to stretch, minimizing damage to the pelvic floor muscles and the likelihood of tears or episiotomy (see p.217). Work with the messages your body is sending you. Breathe into a push, easing the baby down the birth canal; holding your breath makes you pull up rather than bear down. Release the push as each contraction subsides. Your baby moves back a bit, but each push makes gentle progress.